



LORE MASTER'S DECK

TM

GUIDEBOOK

For a tutorial with video, visit
storyenginedeck.com/lore/tutorial

Introduction

The Story Engine®: Lore Master's Deck™ is a set of 300 double-sided cards for creating webs of new and exciting lore for storytelling and worldbuilding. It's a powerful tool for writers, worldbuilders, storytellers, DMs, GMs, and RPG groups.

The only "rule" when using Lore Master's Deck is this:

The goal of the deck is to help you create. Ignore any mechanic that doesn't serve this purpose.

This book contains guidelines to help you weave threads of lore and story as fluidly, imaginatively, and clearly as possible. The deck is designed to be open-ended and creator-driven, so please modify our guidelines to suit your creative process.

How the Deck Works

Lore Master's Deck helps writers and worldbuilders create ideas for fictional factions, figures, events, locations, objects, materials, and creatures, and organize these ideas in a web of connections and relationships.

Each lore element is created by drawing 5 cards, one at a time, and arranging them in an organized stack called a *lore cluster*. Each lore cluster you create will suggest *links* connecting it to other cards or clusters.



When you link multiple lore clusters, the resulting structure is called a *lore web*. A lore web can be small, with just a few connected lore clusters, or it can be massive, consisting of a sprawling network of power-hungry factions, eclectic characters, shocking events, and fantastical creatures. The only limit is your imagination (and available table space)!

Lore Cards

Lore Master's Deck contains 7 types of lore cards, each of which will prompt a different type of element in your lore web.



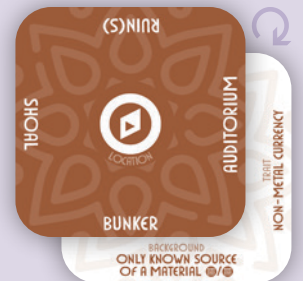
Faction cards represent organized groups of people, from druid circles and political parties to military units and artisan guilds.



Figure cards represent individual people and characters, from wise rulers and anarchic mages to gifted scholars and poetical warlords.



Event cards represent important historical moments, from bloody battles and fractious rebellions to magical cataclysms and powerful storms.



Location cards represent landmarks or geographical areas, from secret springs and labyrinthine cities to fang-filled forests and shattered towers.



Object cards represent significant items and artifacts, from deity-slaying spears and indestructible armor to prophesied amulets and portal-opening lockpicks.



Material cards represent physical materials and resources, from shape-shifting ink and sentient crystals to kinetic metals and undead wood.

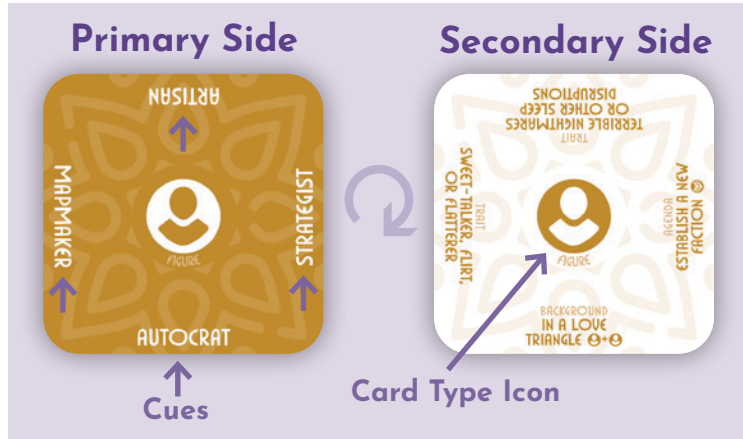


Creature cards represent animals, plants, and other life forms, from carnivorous trees and mountain-sized snails to spell-eating beetles and airborne jellyfish.

How the Cards Work

Every lore card in *Lore Master's Deck* has 2 sides. Each side features 4 cues, which are short suggestions to help you brainstorm new elements or details for your lore web.

The *primary* side of each card features cues printed in white text on a colored background. Primary cues are short, usually just one word, and establish what type of lore element you are adding to your web. For example, will your new  **Figure** be an "autocrat," "strategist," "artisan," or "mapmaker"?



The *secondary* side of the card features cues printed in colored text on a white background. Secondary cues are tucked underneath primary lore cards of the same type to describe them with additional details, such as backgrounds and agendas. Some secondary cues contain links that connect to other lore cards or clusters, indicated by one or more icons at the end of the cue.

Modifier Cards

There is an 8th card type called a  **Modifier** card, which is not considered a lore card and has no primary cues. Instead,  **Modifier** cards have 8 secondary cues (4 per side). These cues take the form of adjectives that modify or describe primary lore cues of any type. The guidebook will tell you when to draw a  **Modifier** card.



Creating a Lore Web

Starting a Lore Cluster

Every lore web begins with a single lore cluster. The starting lore cluster can be of any lore card type, but we recommend new players start with a  **Faction**.

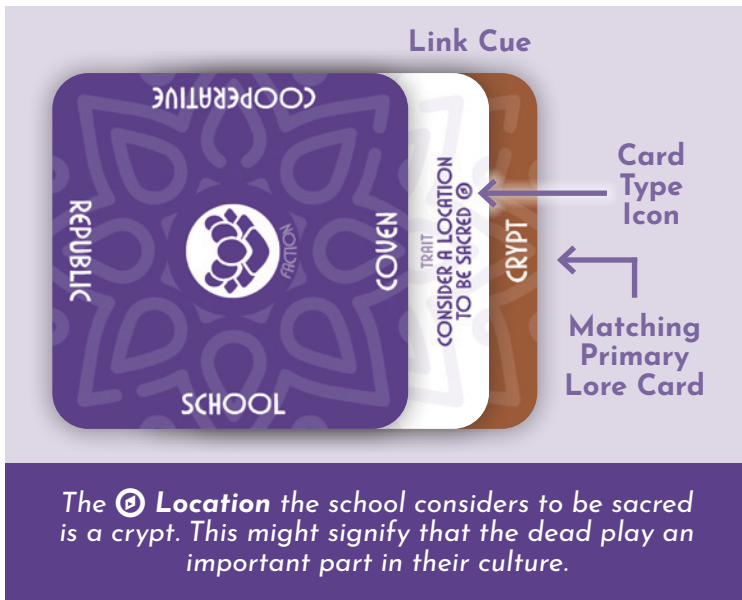
Step 1: Establish a primary card and cue. Draw a lore card of any type and read the 4 primary cues. Pick 1 cue to be the active cue (the cue you will base this lore cluster on). Place the card on the table so the active cue is facing you. Ignore the other 3 cues.



Step 2: Add a secondary cue. Draw a lore card of the same type as the primary card and read the 4 secondary cues. Think about how these details might describe your primary cue and pick 1 cue. Tuck this card underneath any edge of the primary card so only the active cue is visible and the rest are covered.



Step 3: Complete any link cues. Check to see if the cue you added in Step 2 contains any card type icons. If so, you have chosen a link cue, which will connect your current lore cluster to another lore card or cluster. Draw lore card(s) of the type(s) indicated by the icon(s), read the primary cues, and choose 1. Tuck this card under the link cue so only the active cue is showing. See "Link Cues" (p. 5) for additional guidance.



Step 4: Complete the lore cluster with secondary cues. Repeat Steps 2 and 3, continuing to add secondary cues to your lore cluster and completing any link cues as they come up. Stop when all 4 edges of your primary card have a secondary cue. Make sure at least one of the cues you choose is a link cue so you can continue to expand your lore web.

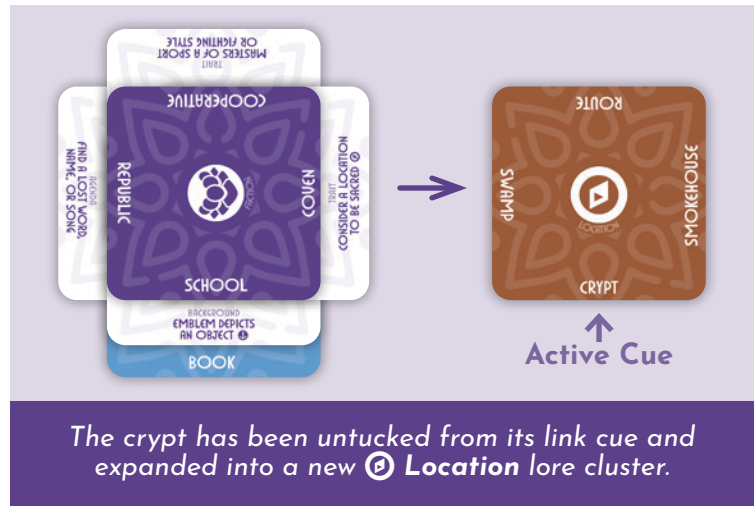
Step 5: Interpret your lore cluster. Review the cues in your lore cluster and take note of any details that spark ideas. Cues are intended to be open-ended, so you are encouraged to read them as literally or metaphorically as you like, and to ignore any cues that you find unhelpful. You are welcome to rearrange the cards in your cluster and change your choice of active cues at any time.



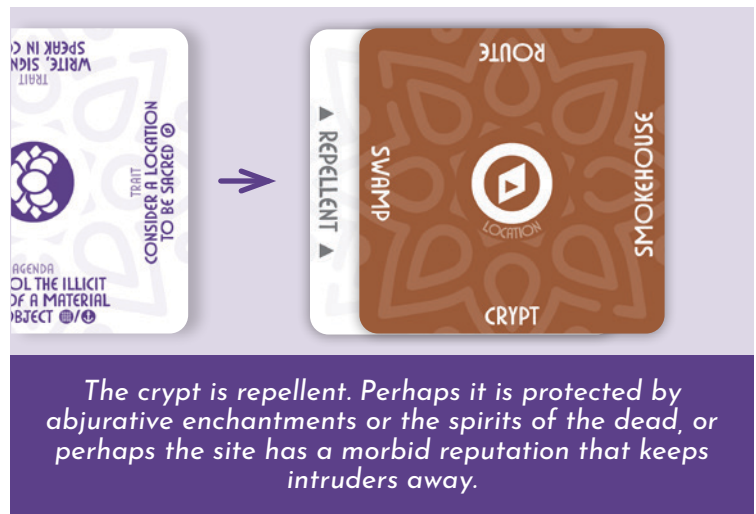
Expanding a Lore Cluster

Your lore web will grow as you expand your link cues into new lore clusters, creating a sprawling grid of story elements connected by threads made up of their backstories, traits, agendas, and more. Expanding a lore cluster works much like starting a new one.

Step 1: Start a new cluster. Review your lore cluster(s) for any primary cues tucked under link cues. Choose a primary cue that represents an element of lore you would like to develop in greater detail. Untuck it, rotate it so the active cue is facing you, and place it in the open space beside its corresponding link cue.

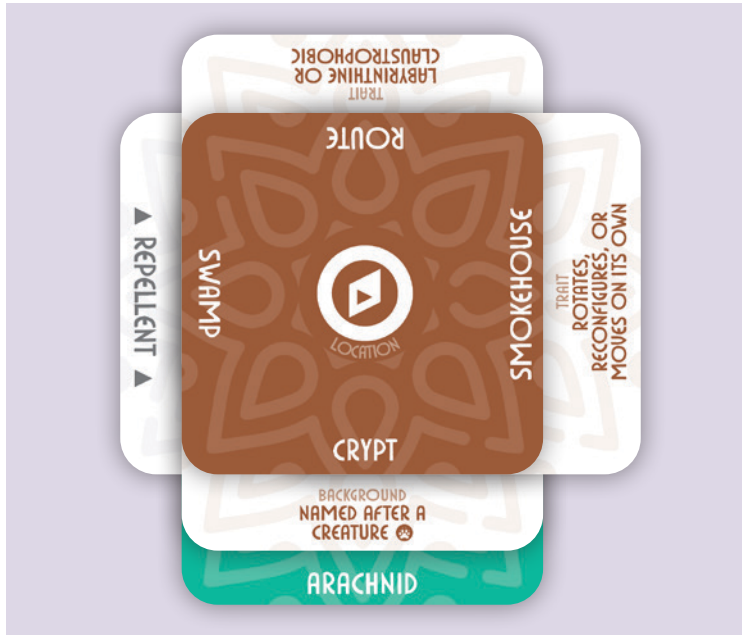


Step 2: Add a Modifier card. Draw a **Modifier** (see p. 3) and read the 8 cues (4 on each side of the card). Choose 1 cue to describe or modify your newly expanded primary card with a new trait. Tuck the **Modifier** under your primary card on the edge of the card adjacent to the lore cluster it expanded from. The arrows on the active cue of the **Modifier** should point from the original cluster toward the expanded lore card.

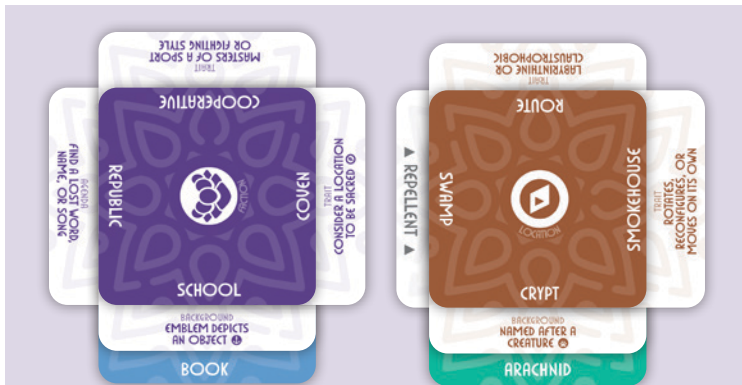


Tip: Need help tracking active cues? Remember: for the first card in each cluster, the active cue is at the bottom facing you. Ignore the other 3 cues. All other cards should be tucked so only the active cue is visible (even if it is oriented sideways or upside-down).

Step 3: Add secondary cues. As in Steps 2 to 4 of “Starting a Lore Web,” draw and tuck secondary cues of the same card type as the primary card until all edges of the primary card are full, choosing at least 1 link cue. Whenever a link cue is tucked, complete it by either drawing new cards, or by choosing an existing lore card or lore cluster from your web that fits the cue. These existing connections can be tracked using link tokens. See the “Link Cues” section for additional guidance.



Step 4: Interpret your lore web. Review the cues in your lore cluster and web. Take notes on any new or expanded ideas. Rearrange cards and adjust their active cues at any time.



Perhaps the school's crypt is physically animated by the spirits of the dead, a living labyrinth of shifting halls that reconfigures itself to protect its secrets. It is called the Crypt of Spiders because of the ghostly white arachnids that sit in silent vigil over the tombs.

Growing a Lore Web

You can continue to expand new lore clusters from your link cues by repeating the steps in “Expanding a Lore Cluster.” If the primary cue you wish to expand is not adjacent to an open space, rearrange the cards in its cluster so it is.

You may expand new lore clusters and grow your lore web for as long as you like. We recommend stopping when you run out of interesting avenues to explore. As the number of lore clusters grows, so will your stockpile of existing lore elements to complete link cues without drawing new cards. When you reach a point where there are no tucked primary cards that you are interested in expanding from their link cues, your lore web is complete.

Alternatively, you may wish to complete your web when you reach a certain goal:

- 30, 60, or 90 minutes have elapsed.
- Your lore web has grown to 5, 10, or 15 lore clusters.
- You have completed 1 lore cluster of each lore card type.
- You have completed 3, 4, or 5 lore clusters of any single card type.

See p. 6 for a sample lore web. When you finish your session, we recommend taking a photo of your lore web so you can refer back to it. Then, shuffle any cards used back into their respective draw piles.

Link Cues

Link cues connect a lore cluster to a new primary lore card or lore cluster, creating a web of story and worldbuilding threads. Every link cue contains one or more icons indicating which card types they link to. However, some link cues and connections follow special guidelines.

Link Tokens for Pre-Existing Links

Before drawing a new lore card to complete a link cue, you can review your lore web for any primary cards of the same type. If one of them fits the suggestion on the cue, you can choose to link those two cards instead of drawing new cards.

These connections can be mapped by placing a path of small *link tokens* between the two linked cards. The print version of *Lore Master's Deck* comes with colored tokens for this purpose, but you can also use paper clips, pennies, or pieces from common board games.

To map a connection, look at the grid of empty space between the lore clusters in your lore web and plan a route that connects the link cue to the nearest corner of the lore cluster that completes it. Place a path of matching tokens along this route (see p. 6).

If you create multiple token paths connecting different connected cards, try to avoid having the paths overlap. Alternatively, use visibly distinct tokens (e.g., paperclips vs pennies, different colored gamepieces, etc.) to help differentiate the overlapped paths.

Link tokens can also be used to expand tucked primary lore cues when you run out of adjacent spaces to expand to.

Tip: Need to retrace the path of your lore web? Follow the arrows! Identify your starting lore cluster by looking for the primary card that doesn't have a Modifier. From there, follow the arrows on the Modifier cards to retrace the connections between each lore cluster.

Example Lore Web



Multiple Choice Link Cues

When a link cue contains multiple icons separated by a slash (/), draw a card for each icon. Choose a single cue and discard all other cards.

BACKGROUND
CRAFTING METHOD
PROTECTED BY A FIGURE
OR FACTION 🧑/🏰

Draw a 🧑 **Figure** and 🏰 **Faction**. Choose 1 primary cue and discard the other card.

Double Card Link Cues

When a link cue contains multiple icons separated by a plus (+), you will need to tuck 2 cards to complete the cue. Draw a card for each icon and tuck 1 primary cue from each card under the link cue together in a stack. Either one of these cards can be expanded into a new lore cluster. If you expand both cards, you may need to place one of the cards in a non-adjacent space and use link tokens to connect them.

BACKGROUND
WON OR LOST
IN A BET BETWEEN
FACTIONS 🏰+🏰

Draw 2 🏰 **Factions**, choose 1 primary cue from each, and tuck them under the link cue. These are the warring factions.

General vs Specific Link Cues

Some link cues are phrased to use primary lore cards as a general example of something rather than a specific instance in your world. For example, some cues link to a 🧑 **Figure** to represent a general profession instead of a specific person, or link to an ⚓ **Object** to represent a general type of equipment or trade good instead of a specific artifact. When you expand a general link cue, you may choose to treat it as one specific instance instead of that general group (e.g., one notable 🧑 **Figure** belonging to a profession).

Sensitive Material*

Some cues in the deck feature an asterisk (*). The asterisk indicates cues that relate to sensitive material that could cause harm if mishandled, including depictions of gender, sex, disability, colonialism, and the experiences of racial and religious minorities.

In storytelling and lore-crafting, we want to represent a diversity of experiences. Some of these we have lived ourselves. Others we have not. When writing about an identity or community we don't belong to, it is important to do research, understand the perspectives and histories of the real-life people involved, and keep in mind the potential harms that might come from appropriation or misrepresentation.

Consider:

- Reviewing commentary and criticism on the topic.
- Reading fiction or watching media made by people with relevant lived experience.
- Consulting a sensitivity reader.

When using *Lore Master's Deck*, we challenge you to question your immediate reactions to the cues and examine biases that may stem from differences in culture, ability, or ways of thinking. Real people and cultures contain multitudes and cannot be reduced to an allegory without flattening them.

No one person represents all the perspectives within a community, and people may disagree on what counts as sensitive material or respectful representation. If sensitive material features prominently in your work and you intend to share or publish it, take extra care.

Note: We on the development team have done our best to note the cues that most benefit from deeper research and care. We also acknowledge our list may be incomplete and imperfect. Like you, we have the goal of exploring different experiences with respect and empathy. Find an updated list of sensitivity cues, along with additional links and guidance, at storyenginedeck.com/lore/sensitivity.

Advanced Guide

As you become experienced with *Lore Master's Deck*, you may discover new uses, rules, and game modes for it. This is highly encouraged!

We have highlighted a few of our favorite advanced modes for using the deck.

Corner Tuck

Sometimes, a secondary card will have 2 cues you want to use. When those cues are on adjacent edges of the card, you can tuck that card around the corner of the primary card, using both cues as active cues.



Multiplayer Lore-Weaving

In this mode, multiple players weave a lore web together, card by card. Follow the normal guidelines for starting and expanding a lore web, but take turns as the acting player.

On their turn, the acting player draws any cards indicated by the instructions, chooses the active cue, and gives a brief description of how they interpret the cue to fit the lore web. Their turn ends when they have added a new secondary cue to the lore web and completed any link cues on that card.

Players may offer each other input, but the acting player always has final say on their turn. Players are encouraged to provide interpretations that build on each other's contributions, rather than contradicting existing lore.

Lore-weaving is the slowest form of multiplayer collaboration, but yields more integrated lore webs.

Multiplayer Lore-Blocking

In this mode, players build a lore web by taking turns creating complete lore clusters. The acting player creates or expands a lore cluster following the normal instructions, explaining their interpretation as they go.

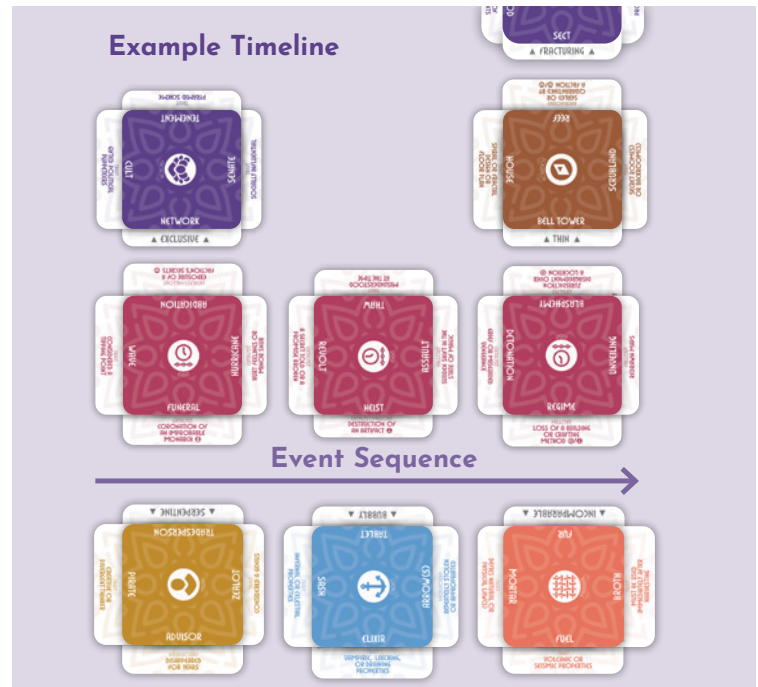
When they complete a lore cluster, the next player chooses a tucked primary cue and expands it into a new lore cluster.

Timeline Lore-Building

In this mode, you create a world timeline by assembling a chronological sequence of miniature lore webs formed around  **Events**.

Begin your first lore web by creating an  **Event** lore cluster. As you add cards to this lore cluster and expand the lore web, tuck any link cues you intend to expand under the top or bottom edges of primary lore cards instead of the sides. Your lore web should grow as a vertical line of lore elements all connected to a single  **Event**.

When your lore web has reached 2 to 4 lore clusters, stop and create a new  **Event**-based lore web. Start with a new  **Event** lore cluster to the left or right of an existing  **Event** lore cluster to indicate whether it occurred before or after that  **Event**. Expand this new lore web vertically as before. Continue adding new  **Event**-based lore webs to your timeline for as long as you like.



You may complete link cues using cards from any point in the timeline you like. The same power groups, characters, landmarks, and artifacts may reappear throughout the major events of your world.

Ready for more advanced lore-weaving? Create lore webs featuring deities, symbols, and names with the *Lore Mastery Expansions*. Find decks and expansions to take your creativity to the next level at storyenginedeck.com/lore.

Incorporating Other Decks

Lore Master's Deck is the third in a series of standalone deck systems available at storyenginedeck.com. It uses card types, icons, and concepts that build on its predecessors. You can use cards from one deck in prompts for another deck to exponentially increase the number of possible combinations. Sometimes, to ensure you have enough options for a suitable cue, you may need to draw extra cards and discard any unused cards.

The Story Engine® Deck is a standalone system for creating story prompts, character concepts, plot hooks, and more.



Deck of Worlds™ is a standalone system for creating fictional worlds and world maps.



Instead of these lore cards...	you can draw these story cards.
👤 Figure	2 👤 Agents
📍 Location or 📍 Object	2 📍 Anchors
🧠 Modifier	2 🧠 Aspects
secondary 👤 Figure or 🏰 Faction	🔧 Engine

Instead of these story cards...	you can draw these lore cards.
👤 Agent	👤 Figure
📍 Anchor	2 of 📍 Event, 📍 Location, 📍 Object, 📍 Material, or 🐾 Creature
🧠 Aspect	🧠 Modifier or secondary card of a type matching the card being described

Instead of these lore cards...	you can draw these world cards.
📍 Location	2 📍 Landmarks or 4 📍 Regions
secondary 📍 Location	📖 Origin

Instead of these world cards...	you can draw these lore cards.
📍 Landmark or 📍 Region	📍 Location
🧠 Attribute	secondary 📍 Location or 🧠 Modifier
🎲 Advent	📍 Event + secondary 📍 Event

You can also use our Bridge Expansions to combine our deck systems in innovative ways that further your creativity. Or wield the power of deities, symbols, and names with our Lore Mastery Expansions.

Credits

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Box art: the *EMBERWIND* RPG, courtesy of Nomnivore Games

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